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IGNOMINY IN ENGLAND

NOT A lot of men can claim to have experienced agony and ecstasy all in one go. I can. My first trip to England was for the 1999 World Cup and in the time we were such an exciting team that we made it all the way to the final at Lord's – the home of cricket – only to lose what will be remembered as the most one-sided World Cup final in history. Truly, the 1999 World Cup saw us at our best and, sadly, at our worst too.

Here's how we started. I opened against the West Indies, in Bristol, getting 11 in 19, and didn't bowl. We won, by 27 runs, in front of what felt like a home crowd. I also opened against Scotland in Chester-le-Street, getting 7 from 9. We won by almost a hundred runs. The Scots helped tick our scoreboard along too when they broke the record for extras conceded (48), maybe because they were hungover, or so their press claimed. Shoaib Akhtar wiped their top order clean. I barely bowled a couple of overs. There was too much movement off the pitch.

By our second week into the tournament, when we were up against Australia in Leeds, I was replaced by Wajahatullah Wasti. Although we won that game by 10 runs, I felt that the inconsistency of Pakistani decision-making was beginning to show. A successful opening combination between Saeed Anwar and me was being played around with, for no odd reason. Keep in mind that in the 10 ODIs Saeed and I played for Pakistan before the 1999 World Cup, we opened together in the last nine matches (for the Coca-Cola Cup and the Pepsi Cup) to put up opening partnerships worth 577 runs for Pakistan, 297 of which were next to my name. So, in my humble opinion, as well as according to the math, there was no need to mess around with our opening combination. And yet, the Pakistani management was doing what it does best: defy logic.

Five days later, against New Zealand in Derby, I was back as opener with Saeed. I scored 17 in 22. Once again, it was Shoaib Akhtar who made a meal of their top order and we won by 62 runs.

One thing that sticks out from that World Cup – something I'd felt very weird about even then – was what happened before our next match, against Bangladesh. Everybody remembers